

What to Include in a Pain Journal

A field list for the facts that make tracking clinically useful instead of decorative.

Routing Note

- Need:** When everything hurts, a blank page can feel like a dare. A checklist is simpler and more honest.
- Tool:** Use it to strip tracking down to what is essential now and ignore the rest until it becomes necessary.
- Rule:** A shorter system you can survive is better than a perfect system you abandon.

Essential (Track Daily)

- ☐ Pain intensity (0–10 scale)
- ☐ Pain location (be specific)
- ☐ Pain type (sharp, dull, burning, throbbing, etc.)
- ☐ Time of day pain occurs
- ☐ Duration of each episode

Important (Track Daily)

- ☐ Medications taken (name, dose, time)
- ☐ Medication effectiveness (% relief, duration)
- ☐ Sleep quality and hours
- ☐ Activities attempted and completed
- ☐ What made pain better or worse

Valuable (Track When Relevant)

- ☐ Mood and emotional state
- ☐ Stress level
- ☐ Weather/barometric pressure
- ☐ Menstrual cycle day (if applicable)
- ☐ Food and hydration
- ☐ Exercise or physical therapy

For Appointments (Weekly Summary)

- ☐ Average pain level this week
- ☐ Worst and best days
- ☐ Functional limitations
- ☐ Questions for your doctor
- ☐ Treatment changes to discuss

Your Tracking Priorities